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CALIFORNIA, HERE WE COME,

RIGHT BACK WHERE WE STARTED FROM

Umber has an unfortunate knack of getting into trouble at school and home. She kicks it with other Desis at school, but often finds herself at the center of gossip and arguments that place her outside of the social circles of which she desperately wants to remain a part. Although she continually promises to be more mindful of her parents' rules, she ends up spending a lot of time alone in her room. Here, she has covered the back of her wall with glossy clippings of her favorite Bollywood stars and confides her secret ambition to make it onto the silver screen. Umber's family was landed gentry in Punjab but moved to Nairobi in the 1940s, where her father was born. From Nairobi they moved to Yuba City, California, in the 1970s to do farm work and stayed until 1983, when they came to San Jose. At first Umber's father worked as a farmer with his brothers in Yuba City, but then went to Chico State University and now has a job in management information systems. He loves to tell Umber and her younger brother stories from his teenage days at Yuba City High School, where he belonged to a bhangra dance troupe.[1] *On his family room wall, he proudly displays a portrait of his dance troupe in full costume from the 1970s. Although he wants a bigger house, he and his wife like this neighborhood and want to remain within walking distance of their relatives. Like many Desi families, Umber's grandparents live with them and take care of the children when they get home from school, which has helped their parents save money on child care. "You really need an education these days," her father reflected. Gesturing to his three-bedroom tract home, he remarked, "If you want a house like this, it is already over half a million. You have to work for it." Umber shrugged indifferently as she asked her parents for the fourth time if she might go to the mall with her friends.*

Desi families like Umber's have helped to establish a strong Desi Community in Silicon Valley. They have created a space for themselves in residential neighborhoods, the retail landscape, public culture, and especially the high-tech industry. Over the past few decades, the surge in high-tech jobs has made Silicon Valley an attractive place for families like Umber's, who are in search of lucrative careers as well as steady, well-paying nonskilled labor positions. Of all the influences in this region, technology reigned supreme in the late 1990s. The development of the high-tech industry and its pervasive narratives of progress, innovation, and success have had an indelible impact on Desi migration to Silicon Valley. This industry has drawn thousands of people with what I call "the promise of technology," and it continues to shape the lives and aspirations of its Desi residents. From the beginning high-tech labor has been polarized into an exceedingly wealthy professional class and a struggling laboring class that has had to cope with the industry's cyclical nature. This configuration has primarily attracted upper-middle-class professional Desis in search of white-collar tech work, as well as working-class Desis who gradually became middle class and have high hopes that their children are upwardly mobile as well. Such socioeconomic differences shape neighborhoods and social life for Desis as they transform the landscape and population of this region.

Desi families flocked to Silicon Valley from South Asia and other parts of the United States, as well as other diasporic locations in the United Kingdom, Canada, and Fiji, and established supportive communities that they work hard to maintain. Large, visible Desi communities settled into neighborhoods with religious places of worship are ubiquitous in Desi Land, but were barely a possibility until the past few decades. Over the span of a century, Desis have moved up in status, from being undesirable, racially non-White immigrants to sought after residents whose ambiguous racial status skews closer to White. Changes in immigration policy, victories of the civil rights movement, the emergence of the model minority myth, and the rise of multiculturalism all contribute to these changes.

Yet all is not sunny in California. The title of this chapter, which fans of televised teenage drama may recognize as lyrics from *The OC* show opening, emphasizes that while Silicon Valley is indeed more diverse than predominantly White, wealthy California communities such as those in Orange County, it is nonetheless plagued by discrimination against race,

class, and gender. Although many Desis have prospered in ways that early Punjabi settlers could not have imagined, dynamics of inequality still exist among Desis and become increasingly apparent during times of social and economic difficulty. During these times especially, community support is paramount.

Desi communities generate ideas of success and create intergenerational connections. These social formations set the stage for Desi teen culture and shape how teens relate to their family, school, and California. As is true for other immigrant groups in this region, notions of Desi success, progress, and mobility are community-specific and locally defined (Freeman 1989). In Silicon Valley in the 1990s, high tech held great promise for quick wealth without traditional educational qualifications. With stories of teenage millionaires circulating, Desi teens looked to high tech with great hopes. Such aspirations are addressed intergenerationally as adults in Desi communities try to help youth achieve their goals. How communities create ideas of success and how success can be achieved vary according to class. Both middle- and upper-middle-class Desis, however, turned toward the high-tech industry with their aspirations of achieving the Amrikan Dream.

THE RISE OF SILICON VALLEY HIGH TECH

The high-tech industry has brought about myriad changes in the population, landscape, and narratives of progress. Silicon Valley burgeoned from what, as recently as the 1950s, were agricultural lands into a major player in the global economy. Silicon Valley begins about thirty-five miles south of San Francisco and encompasses fifteen hundred square miles extending through San Jose (S. Cohen and Fields 2000). Santa Clara is the heart of Silicon Valley, and the wider boundaries encompass Palo Alto to the north and San Jose to the south. Santa Clara County was instrumental in the Gold Rush in the 1850s because it was home to one of the first mining corporations and the largest quicksilver (mercury) mine, an element essential to extracting gold and silver from raw ore (Pellow and Park 2002: 34–35). Once a bountiful stretch of agricultural land, the urban sprawl now known as Silicon Valley once went by a collection of other names, including "The Valley of Heart's Delight" and the "The Prune Capital of America" (Khanna 1997: 67).

The birth of Silicon Valley is generally traced to the establishment of Shockley Superconductor in 1956, though some mark 1939—the year William Hewlett and David Packard formed their partnership—as its true start (Kenney 2000). "Silicon" refers to silicon dioxide, the material used to make semiconductor chips through an elaborate and expensive process. "Valley" refers to flat Santa Clara County, which is flanked by the Diablo Mountain Range on the east and the Santa Cruz mountain range on the west (Khanna 1997). Silicon was used by William Shockley and two others to invent the transistor at Bell Laboratories in New York in 1947. Silicon soon began to replace germanium, and the transistor industry took root in Santa Clara when a former employee of Shockley left to form his own enterprise (G. Matthews 2003). Silicon Valley was thus named in 1971, when the journalist Don Hoefler wrote a three-part series on the history of the semiconductor industry for *Electronic News* (Khanna 1997: 67). Other Silicon Valley articles appeared in the early 1970s in *Fortune* magazine, and by 1975 the place had become a location in the public imagination (Kenney 2000).

The high-tech industry flourished in this California landscape (C.-M. Lee et al. 2000). Land was affordable and builders faced few initial bureaucratic constraints; moreover, parcels of undeveloped land were ideal for business parks and campuses (Li and Park 2006). During the 1950s and 1960s, Stanford University played a key role in high-tech innovation, as start-ups and companies gravitated toward the semirural land around the campus (Saxenian 1985). From its early days, Silicon Valley has been a production hub in what Manuel Castells (1985: 25) has termed the "Warfare State," a term used to refer to the growth of military-related production and the corresponding development of certain urban regions in the United States. Electronics production for military use, such as microwave tubes for aerospace and satellite use, flourished in this region shortly after World War II in companies such as Lockheed-Martin and computer companies such as Sun Microsystems (Leslie 2000). Silicon Valley has also been a leader in television, radio, and other electronic innovation (Sturgeon 2000). A handful of other industries have also established themselves in this area. For example, in 1955, the Ford Motor Company opened a plant in Milpitas, a town sandwiched between San Jose and Fremont, and remained active until the 1980s.

In recent decades, Silicon Valley has seen several cycles of rapid growth

and decline. The 1970s were eventful venture capital years. Steve Jobs and Steve Wozniak produced the first microcomputer in a garage and in 1976 launched Apple Computers (Castells 1996). By the mid-1980s, over 70 percent of residents worked in high tech and a significant portion of the remaining 30 percent worked in service or support, a trend I saw during my research a decade and a half later. The 1980s began with major successes, but the late 1980s saw a downturn in the stock market. Though the region then went through a decline, this was reportedly due to external forces rather than a lack of entrepreneurial enthusiasm. The next decade continued the 1980s slump but picked up by the mid-1990s, a time when the stock market was more receptive to initial public offerings (IPOs; Kenney and Florida 2000: 19). Such ebbs and flows, perhaps most dramatically in the bubble of the late 1990s and its subsequent burst in 2000, suggest that the high-tech industry is cyclical in its growth but persists despite setbacks.

High-Tech Globalization and Flexibility • Flexibility of capital and labor imbue Silicon Valley with its global character. The rapid development of this region coincided with, as well as contributed to, the restructuring of capitalism that occurred in the late twentieth century (Castells 1996; see also Harvey 1990; Jameson 1991; Lash and Urry 1987). Like the postwar growth of other regions of the United States, such as Route 128 in Massachusetts, Silicon Valley has played a pivotal role in transforming society from the industrial to the informational age (Saxenian 1985: 82).[2] Fordist mass production has been replaced by advanced capitalism, and the shift from product- to process-oriented economies has flourished in Silicon Valley (Angel 2000). Such new economies modify urban areas and position Silicon Valley as a powerful player in the world economy. Saskia Sassen (1991) terms these dynamic metropoles "global cities" and notes the rise of informational industries that have transformed the nature of urban spaces and are central to globalization. Venture capital has been critical to the growth and development of technological and entrepreneurial projects, as well as the continued growth of Silicon Valley (Kenney and Florida 2000).

Labor is also flexible in Silicon Valley. Although since 2001 the region has been experiencing the latest wave of outsourcing to South Asia and other regions of the world in the form of data processing and call centers,

the practice of outsourcing labor is not new in Silicon Valley. As early as 1963, Fairchild, a founding firm of Silicon Valley, built an assembly plant in Hong Kong (G. Matthews 2003: 230). The flexibility of labor arrangements is perhaps most stark in the practice called "body-shopping," in which workers are solicited from other countries to live and work in the United States on temporary visas (type H1-B). The quota of H1-B temporary workers rose dramatically during the late 1990s. Of those who were body-shopped, nearly half came from India to work in computer-related occupations (Aneesh 2006).[3] These body-shopped laborers reported glass ceilings at work and racial tension in society (Prashad 2000). These decades of growth in Silicon Valley have initiated both growth and diversification of local populations.

Of all these periods, the late 1990s and 2000 are the years for which Silicon Valley is most renowned for its international power and status. By 1993, the region had once again picked up, and the United States began to outproduce Japan in microchip manufacturing (G. Matthews 2003). The area had added about 200,000 jobs since 1997, and average annual wages during this time were $46,000, compared to the U.S. average of $29,000 (S. Cohen and Fields 2000). Silicon Valley had a population of about 2.3 million in 2000 and about 1.2 million jobs. By 2000, the region was reported to be 150 percent more prosperous than the national average (S. Cohen and Fields 2000). At the height of the high-tech industry, Chinese and Indian engineers were running one-fourth of Silicon Valley's high-tech businesses and their companies had accounted for over 58,000 jobs and $16.8 billion in sales (G. Matthews 2003).

TRANSFORMING LANDSCAPES AND POPULATIONS

During several decades of rapid transformation, technology swiftly established an economic and cultural hegemony over this region, so much so that it has earned the name "technoburb" (Li and Park 2006: 121). In stark contrast to its bucolic past, contemporary descriptors of the region emphasize its modernity and international qualities. In the late 1990s, billboards on the strip of Highway 101 that connects San Francisco to San Jose via numerous towns in between that make up Silicon Valley attested to the centrality of technology in this region. Rather than including a smattering of the usual products—movies, drinks, airlines, banks—nearly every bill-

board advertised something related to technology. From must-visit websites to promises of superior networking infrastructure, there were barely any signs of life outside the high-tech industry. When I began my fieldwork in 1999, there were but a few remaining patches of former farmland waiting to be converted to corporate parks and housing.

Such dramatic commercial and residential growth has brought about a spate of problems, including environmental concerns, poor public planning, and an exceedingly high cost of living (Khanna 1997). Pollution due to toxic waste from semiconductor chips as well as defense production has been so menacing that it has earned the former "Valley of Heart's Delight" the unfortunate moniker "The Valley of Toxic Fright" (Pellow and Park 2002: 19). Transportation problems, congestion, and auto-emission pollution routinely violate EPA standards. While residents of the foothills can distance themselves from these problems to an extent, the less wealthy residents are unable to escape it. Even in the 1970s and 1980s job development far outpaced housing, causing a constant shortage of living space (Rogers and Larsen 1984). In order to avoid residential overcrowding while still raising much-needed tax revenue, extensive tracts of land were rezoned for industrial use, and this further exacerbated the housing shortage. Even worse, most places were zoned for single-unit rather than multiple-unit dwellings (Saxenian 1985).

San Jose is now the largest and most densely populated city in the Bay Area, overshadowing the nearby cities of San Francisco and Oakland. Real estate developers who continue to build at a furious pace have colonized areas of San Jose that were previously farmland or bare. Luxurious gated communities of multimillion-dollar homes in the surrounding foothills that had been sparsely populated before the high-tech boom began to flank small, modest homes built on flat expanses. Brand new developments of identical, boxy, supersized McMansions have cropped up all over the foothills in San Jose and Fremont and make the older tract houses in the flat regions of the valley look even more diminutive. The newness of these communities is apparent everywhere, from the newly seeded lawns and recently planted trees to the pristine streets and sidewalks.

From the 1970s until the present, the high-tech industry has drawn waves of immigrants into this region. Glenna Matthews (2003) notes the fateful confluence of the 1965 Immigration Act with the evolution of Silicon Valley as a high-tech center: San Jose's foreign-born population

went from 7.6 percent in 1970 to 26.5 percent in 1990 and continues to grow as family reunification further expands these numbers. In the past two decades, particularly between 1990 and 2000, California in general and Silicon Valley in particular have experienced tremendous population expansion, most of which is due to high numbers of Asian immigrants. Thousands have arrived from Mainland China, Taiwan, Hong Kong, Vietnam, Philippines, and South Asia to work in Silicon Valley (Li and Park 2006; Wong 2006). Unlike earlier waves of European immigrants, who entered the United States in the Northeast, contemporary immigrants have been disproportionately concentrated in the West. California edged New York out of the distinction of being the highest receiving state by accounting for over 33 percent of legal immigrants while New York accounted for only 14 percent (Portes and Zhou 1995: 38).

This growth of Asian Americans in Silicon Valley is the latest in a long history of dramatic demographic shifts. Santa Clara County, in which Silicon Valley is located, has experienced waves of settlers over the centuries. Initially settled by Ohlone Native Americans, the area saw the arrival of the Spanish explorer Gaspar de Portolá in 1769, gold diggers during the Rush, Chinese who came to build railroads in the same period, Mexican laborers who came to work in the fields, and European cannery workers in the 1950s and 1960s. During the heyday of the U.S. automobile industry, Portuguese farmers primarily tended to the agriculture in the region while Ford employed Mexican, Filipino, and African American autoworkers who settled in Milpitas and the surrounding areas of San Jose and Fremont. Mexican Americans, whom I also refer to as Latinos or Chicanos, have had a strong, long-standing presence in the South Bay (Pitti 2003; Zlolniski 2006).[4] This region was further diversified by the arrival of a wave of Vietnamese immigrants after the fall of Saigon in 1975 who came in search of work and affordable housing.

This trend has continued, as the 2000 census indicates that California's overall population grew 13.8 percent to 33.9 million over the past decade, and its Asian American population has grown 55 percent since 1990. At 4.2 million, Asian Americans now constitute 12 percent of the state's population, outpacing the growth of all other groups. California has the largest South Asian population in the United States, 143,206 of whom live in the San Francisco Bay Area (Zhou 2004). Within the Asian category, Silicon Valley now hosts the state's largest Desi population, a distinction

held by Los Angeles a mere decade ago. Asian Americans are concentrated in San Jose, which is 28.8 percent Asian American, while Fremont reported 39.8 percent.[5] Overall, Silicon Valley's high-tech employment boom contributed to a 97 percent increase in the Desi population, which grew to 314,819. San Jose has experienced a 149 percent increase, and Fremont's Desi population shot up 272 percent, which, along with increases of 318 percent in Santa Clara and 528 percent in Sunnyvale, accounts for most of Silicon Valley.

Thus, a region formerly dominated by European American immigrants who were integral to fruit picking and packing is now home to a massive influx of immigrants from Asia as well as Asian Americans. In these diverse, ethnically saturated residential "ethnoburbs" (Li and Park 2006), Asian Americans have built a strong residential and retail presence. Hong Kong developers have transformed small retail complexes into shopping meccas (G. Matthews 2003). Entirely Asian shopping centers, Asian-owned banks, and distinctive places of worship, among other markers, signify a shift toward a far more ethnically diverse region. The 1997 opening of Ranch 99 in Milpitas distinguished itself as the largest Asian American shopping area in the United States, containing stores, restaurants, bookstores, and grocery outlets. On opening day, over 95 percent of the shoppers were Asian American, including a sizable Taiwanese population (Chang 2006: 104–5). In this retail flurry, the Ford Motor plant, which closed in 1983, received an extreme makeover when it was bought by Chinese businessmen and transformed into The Great Mall, featuring restaurants, arcades, and designer outlet stores.[6] In this transforming landscape, Desi Land has taken root and continues to grow.

CREATING DESI LAND IN CALIFORNIA

Changes in immigration policy enabled Desis to form close-knit communities that have created a fertile setting for the emergence of Desi teen culture. The ability to create such a visible and rooted presence is a notable shift from earlier Californian Desis. Desi immigrants who arrived before 1965 lacked basic civil rights and were unable to achieve a critical mass that Desis today take for granted. The first lone immigrant from India arrived in Salem, Massachusetts in 1820 (Helweg and Helweg 1990: 46). During the remainder of the nineteenth century, fewer than 700 people

from India entered (Jensen, cited in Rangaswamy 2000: 3). Between 1901 and 1910, more than 3,000 men came to take advantage of California's agricultural opportunities (Leonard 1992). Although most of these early arrivals were Sikhs from Punjab, along with some Muslims and Hindus, they were lumped under the category of "Hindoo" (Song 1998). Between 1907 and 1920, approximately 6,400 Indians entered (Hess 1976), a relatively modest number compared to the influx of 380,000 Chinese, 430,000 Japanese, and 150,000 Filipinos (Bhardwaj and Rao 1990). The Immigration Act of 1917, also referred to as the Asiatic Barred Zone Act, effectively ended immigration from Asia between 1917 and 1946 (Leonard 1997).

Although they were far fewer in number than other Asian immigrants at the time, early "Hindoos" were especially reviled. Termed "the Hindoo invasion," these immigrants were socially isolated and subject to all manner of discrimination as well as less pay than their fellow Asian laborers (Hess 1976). Their turbans and beards elicited more prejudice than the Japanese immigrants experienced, and their illiteracy did not help matters (Leonard 1997). Numerous headlines appeared in local California papers that fueled existing ill will toward this group.

In 1907, violence erupted against Indian immigrants in Washington State. They, along with African Americans, were considered social and economic liabilities, so much so that in 1913 in Port Angeles, California, real estate brokers agreed not to sell real estate to "Hindoos or Negroes . . . [because they] have depreciated value of adjacent property and injured the reputation of the neighborhood, and are generally considered undesirable" (quoted in Hess 1976: 161). A 1909 federal Immigration Commission report describes this group as unable to assimilate, and a 1920 report by the California State Board of Control similarly states, "The Hindu is the most undesirable immigrant in the state. His lack of personal cleanliness, his low morals, and his blind adherence to theories and teachings so entirely repugnant to American principles make him unfit for association with American people" (quoted in Leonard 1992: 24).

In the constant struggle over who is and is not to be considered White, Desis, like other "nondesirable" but necessary immigrant groups, were consistently left in the blind spot of racial definition or fell subject to its aberrant nature. Citizenship was premised on race, but little had been established regarding racial categories and meanings. "Asian" was an especially ambiguous category. Chinese and Japanese were both deemed

"Asiatic," making the Chinese ineligible for citizenship and barred from immigration after the 1882 Chinese Exclusion Act. Japanese settlers continued to immigrate but were denied citizenship after the U.S. Supreme Court's ruling in 1922 in *Ozawa v. United States*. Indians, however, presented a curious case because they were not clearly defined as "Asiatic." Yet their brown skin tone and other phenotypic features precluded them from blending in with Whites. Several Desis were able to make early successful cases to individual judges that Indians were of Aryan descent and therefore "White" (Helweg and Helweg 1990: 54).

A landmark decision, however, clarified early racial ambiguity for Desis. In the 1923 case of the *United States v. Bhagat Singh Thind*, Indians were declared ineligible for citizenship because they are not White (Prashad 2000). Before this case, sixty-nine members of the "Hindu race" had been naturalized (Leonard 1992: 84). In the realm of citizenship, Hindoos struggled in court to be seen as White persons; the *Thind* case denied claims that Indians shared the same Aryan heritage as those from northern and western Europe. (Hess 1976: 170). This case set into motion shifting and arbitrary parameters for the racial status of Desis and what Whiteness means in the United States. Under these conditions, maintaining an ethnically exclusive community was out of the question. Laws now prohibited Hindoos from sponsoring spouses or brides for immigration, owning land, or marrying Whites. Their most available recourse was to marry Mexican American women and place their assets in their wife's and children's names.[7]

In the mid- to late twentieth century in America, several immigration acts contributed to a rapid growth of Desi communities (Brown 2006). The U.S. government repealed the Chinese exclusion laws in 1943, passed the 1945 War Brides Act, and relaxed the Asian exclusion laws in the early 1950s. After 1946, naturalization became possible and quotas of 100 people per year were allowed to emigrate from India (Helweg and Helweg 1990: 46). Between 1946 and 1965, nearly 6,000 immigrants moved to the United States (Hess 1976: 158), many of whom were students, businessmen, refugees, and "twice migrants."[8] It was only in 1965 that the quota system that had limited immigration from certain countries was finally eliminated. The Hart-Cellar Act, as it was known, set a new quota of 20,000 from each country. It also established a system of preferred categories for immigration, including highly skilled labor that the United States

needed, and allowed family unification. This resulted in a rapid and substantial growth of immigration from Asia, nearly 7 million between 1970 and 2000. Desis first appeared in the U.S. Census in 1980 under the category "Asian Indians," prior to which they were in the Asian "other" category. They have grown from 361,531 in 1980 to 815,447 in 1990 to 1,899,599 in 2000 (Zhou 2004). By 2000, they constituted 16 percent of the total Asian American population of 11,906,680. Though Asian Americans (Asian alone or Asian in combination) are only 4.2 percent of the reported 281.4 million U.S. population, they are one of the country's fastest growing population (Ong 1996: 740).

Desi Communities in Silicon Valley • Over the past two decades, Desi communities in Silicon Valley have grown from small, often socially isolated sets of families to large, bustling entities. Both middle-class and upper-middle-class Desis organize themselves into communities based on shared religion, language, nationality, class status, geographical proximity, and sometimes caste. Upper-middle-class families live in the San Jose hills and in Fremont. They are predominantly Gujarati Hindus and Pakistani Muslims, as well as some Sikh Punjabis and Hindus from South India and Maharashtra. In most of these families, one or both parents are well-educated professionals who immigrated after 1965. The main earner, usually the father, has a graduate degree, a stable job with benefits in a white-collar profession, and speaks English fluently. Often the mother has a comparable occupational status, and the family owns a large home in a recently built development.

During the early 1990s, upper-middle-class families that lived in older homes around Fremont and San Jose used their profits from the technology boom to buy homes in newly built gated communities. By high school, upper-middle-class teens lived in large, well-appointed homes with luxury automobiles that they frequently upgraded. These children attend high-performing public schools with other wealthy Asian American and White youth and are often bound for competitive four-year colleges. They aspire to make their mark on the high-tech industry, medicine, or some other professional field.

Middle-class families in this study are primarily Sikh Punjabis or Hindu and Muslim Indo-Fijians and reside in East San Jose. Many of these families moved to San Jose from Yuba City and other parts of California within

the past twenty-five years, when they left farming to seek work in the high-tech industry. There are also a number of Malayalee Christians as well as Indo-Fijian families who moved for economic reasons as well as to escape the growing hostility toward those of Indian descent in Fiji. Most middle-class Desi adults are employees of local Silicon Valley technology companies and work on assembly lines, as janitorial and cafeteria staff, and as local delivery people. Some parents have worked at the same company for over a decade and have advanced in the roster of assembly line tasks. Occasionally they are partners in small businesses and co-own convenience marts, liquor stores, or similar outlets. Most middle-class youth live with their nuclear family and sometimes a live-in grandparent in a single-family home in diverse neighborhoods populated with Asian Americans, Latinos, and African Americans of a similar class status.

There are notable commonalities and differences between the schools that upper-middle-class and middle-class Desis attend and how they are able to position themselves in these institutions. The high-tech boom of the 1980s and 1990s contributed to a general overcrowding, and as of 2000, Mercer, Greene, and Waverly high schools were all enrolled at 75 to 125 percent over their capacities. This predicament has reprioritized administrators' agendas and led them to focus primarily on basic tasks of discipline and curriculum; such a move places the onus of getting what one needs from the school squarely on the student. These faculty and administrators, who are largely White or Latino, have also had an exceedingly challenging time dealing with the religious, linguistic, and cultural diversity of their changing student bodies. This influx includes South Asian and East Asian teens, asylum cases from Iran and Afghanistan, Vietnamese who arrived after the end of Vietnam War, and a growing population of Hmong refugees from Laos. Coupled with the increasingly diverse needs of a Latino community that has long been underserved by California school districts, the character of this region has changed dramatically and rapidly.

Most upper-middle-class Desi teens attend Mercer High School and, to a lesser extent, Greene High School. Located in South Fremont, Mercer High School has 2,249 mostly upper-middle-class youth in ninth through twelfth grades; the school's racial composition is 54 percent Asian American (about one-third South Asian American), 41 percent White, 3 percent Latino, 1 percent African American, and less than 1 percent Native Ameri-

can. Mercer is ranked as a top public high school according to California State standards, and families scramble to enroll their children into its feeder schools and acquire a legitimate address in the area.[9] Those who have learned of the reputation of the best school in Silicon Valley come from as far away as Tokyo, Mumbai (Bombay), London, and other parts of the United States.

Class-based tension is intense at Mercer. Newer Asian American arrivals purchase homes costing more than a million dollars, while White and Latino families watch homes they have occupied for at least a generation soar in value. Angela Shen, the only Asian American teacher at Mercer, commented, "The poor kids almost inevitably are White or Hispanic. They are the ones that can afford to live here because theirs is a house passed down by a grandparent, whereas almost all the people who are moving have to have money because the property values are so high." The struggle to find residential real estate within the school zone is as fierce as the competition among students to succeed. The declaration of twenty valedictorians in the class of 2000 was, according to some school faculty, a promise of even grander successes to come.

Middle-class youth attend either Waverley or Greene High School in southeast San Jose. Greene had 2,648 students during the 1999–2000 school year and a racial composition of 53 percent Asian American, 28 percent Latino, 12 percent White, 6 percent African American, and less than 1 percent Native American. Here, the tension between middle-class and upper-middle-class students is most pronounced. Middle-class students live in the small, single-story homes surrounding the school, while upper-middle-class youth drive down from posh new gated communities in the hills. Of the three high schools, Waverly had the fewest Desis. During the 1999–2000 school year, Waverly High School had 2,154 students and a racial composition of 51 percent Latino, 39 percent Asian American, 5 percent African American, and 5 percent White. It is known locally as a problem school, rife with gang-related incidents and at-risk students. While some kids used the adjective "ghetto" to describe it, most admit its reputation has improved through a mandatory "common dress" code and other adjustments. My initial assumption about Desi kids who attended Waverly was not entirely accurate. A number of them attend because they live in the low-income neighborhoods surrounding the

school, but many others do so because it is a "magnet school" for those planning to study medicine.[10] Those who elect to attend Waverly are especially motivated, but the growing numbers of Desi teens who live in the Waverly attendance area tend to participate less in school activities and struggle with their studies. Regardless of the school they attend, these teens and their families are active members of their communities.

Settling into Neighborhoods • From building places of religious worship to supporting one another in business, politics, and social endeavors, community networks are especially invaluable during times of economic, political, and social instability. Families relied heavily on one another when they first moved to this area and continue to do so. Settling into residences close to a place of worship is especially important to Sikh and Muslim families. Proximity to a *musjid* (mosque) or *gurdwara* (Sikh temple) eliminates the need for transportation and enables elderly relatives and others to regularly attend prayer services. Many Pakistani Muslim families in Fremont as well as Fijian Muslim families in San Jose live close to and worship at a musjid with other members of their community. While Hindu families mention their routine visits to temple, many pray at homes on a daily basis and so are less likely to prioritize living close to a temple.

Over the years, the streets around the San Jose gurdwara have become saturated with Sikh families. One teen's grandfather, whose family has been in San Jose since the late 1970s, explained the inception of the gurdwara in the 1980s: "When we first came to San Jose, there were not so many people of Indian origin. There were only twenty-five Punjabi families here in 1980. We had no resources to buy land for the gurdwara. Slowly we made commitments and now there are thousands of families and due to their efforts, we have a gurdwara here, which is worth $2.2 million. We also bought forty acres of land for a new gurdwara that is also worth $2 million. Within a year or two it will come up.[11] This is a great progression of our community." Middle-class teens and their families from both Waverly and Greene regularly attended this gurdwara. On a walk around this neighborhood, Umber, the middle-class girl whom you met at the start of this chapter whose family has lived on the street next to the gurdwara for about a decade, divulged to me the names and personal information of at least a dozen Indian families who live within a three-block radius. Al-

though all the homes in this tract are nearly identical, the overwhelming aroma of masala wafting down the street quickly differentiated her aunt's house from the other three- and four-bedroom homes that surround it.

Regardless of their class status or religious background, families settle near one another and socialize regularly to maintain their close and supportive networks. Ananya, an upper-middle-class girl, describes how her family's Oria community network initially lived in Massachusetts, where her father was working at MIT. She reports that her father was the first president of the Oria Society of America and that a number of those families decided to move to California en masse. As this group keeps growing, the original group has taken to calling itself "senior citizens of the Oria community, all those old families. There are new people that come, a few families that come every month. There must be two hundred families in the Bay Area." When communities grow to be as large as Ananya's, families rarely socialize with Desis outside of their ethnic groups.

Seeing friends and family is a daily occurrence for Desis, and seldom do days go by without social calls and casual get-togethers. Mrs. George, middle-class mother of Deepa, recalls when there were so few Malayalee Christian families that everyone knew each other and continually gathered in each other's homes. Now there are so many families, each large and extended, she exclaimed, "You can't have everyone in the house! Like my one family, if I invite them, this house is full already." Mrs. George conjectured why these parties remain so ethnically insular. She has a lot of friends from work that she would like to socialize with more, but, she remarked, "It's boring for them. For example, you feel left out, even if I invite you with the group. I have to ask you every minute if you are okay, and still you feel left out, because you don't understand the language and food and culture. I have a lot friends from other groups, Filipino and Americans, but I don't call them." As Mrs. George notes, Desi families enjoy commonalities of language and cultural background within their own ethnic and linguistic community. Feroze, a middle-class boy, asserted, "My family has become the socialite elite among the Bangladesh community. We know everybody, so we get invited to everybody's houses. At least once a month, there's a seventy-person party at our house. So it's insane!" As Feroze suggests, communities can become so large and established that people barely have time to fulfill their own social obligations of

weddings and graduation and dinner parties, let alone routinely venture outside of their circle.

Reciprocity and social and economic support are the backbone of these relationships. Mrs. Malik, the mother of Taahir, explained, "Every other weekend there's a Desi party, on Sunday or Friday or Saturday night. I think when you go to people's parties all the time, you have to have an excuse for giving one. Like two months ago, people were coming back from hajj and there were parties every weekend." Mrs. Malik affirms that leaving some families out is not an option. This can make gatherings for established families exceedingly large. Umber reflected that her family has grown over the past three generations of living in California. Her father noted that getting the entire family in one home is no longer an option and joked, "We have too many relatives [here]—at least five hundred—if you want to get everyone together you need a fairground!" He quickly added that he greatly values this preponderance of relatives, and that he is very lucky that he and his brothers have helped each other with down payments for their homes. For Desis, socializing is not a frivolity or simply a leisure activity; rather, it is a central part of how bonds of community are forged and maintained.

While numerous families laud the support and comfort afforded by their social networks, there are drawbacks, especially when families do not get along well. Janvi, a middle-class Sikh girl, expressed her disillusionment with her extended family and community. As we sat in a Wendy's restaurant in San Jose, she picked at her fries while recounting that her family had a hard time since they moved from India to Yuba City and then San Jose. Her mother, the only daughter-in-law in her husband's family, was given the responsibility of cooking, cleaning, and taking care of their entire extended family when they lived in Yuba City in one large house and the men worked on farms. Even through her relatives have moved with them to San Jose, her parents have felt alienated from the rest of the family. "My dad feels very lonely out here—he has no allies," she lamented.

Other teens feel protective of their parents and are careful that people do not exploit their trusting nature. Preeti, a middle-class Sikh girl, explained, "When me and my sister were young, they used to be close to other people, but as we started growing up, they realized that they can't trust a lot of other friends. My uncle's wife used to steal from my mom,

and now that we're older, she knows better than to do anything mean to my mom." Other families, too, report problems such as stealing, betraying trust, and asking for help without offering it to others. Such families are still invited to all gatherings but are often the subject of gossip afterward. Desi teens and their families note these downsides to community as problematic, but such breaches rarely cause complete breaks from family.

From childhood, Desi teens are included in and inculcated into extensive family and community interaction. In family contexts, many Desi youth are socialized to participate in intergenerational rather than peer-exclusive interaction. They enjoy attending family and community events and readily interact with adults and peers alike. Abhijeet, a middle-class boy, described how he spends a lot of his leisure time: "On the weekends we chill with our grandparents in Yuba City, or with aunts in Sacramento, or in San Jose. We visit family a lot, I have lots cousins, some are older and done with high school. But we all kick it together." This sense of ownership and pride in spending time with family and community is a commonly expressed sentiment among these middle-class Desi teens. Upper-middle-class Desi teens are also invested in their communities. Mr. Patel remarked about his daughter Tara and his son, "They come to cultural events not because we force them to. Around age ten or eleven, Tara discovered boys and she started going with us. Same with my son, they go to the *garba* [a Gujarati group dance] because they want to do it, because it is a social place to see other kids." At community events, both peer and intergenerational connections are maintained.

For middle- as well as upper-middle-class teens, there is significant social continuity between school and home, as community networks spill over into schools. Although teens experience a great deal of peer policing at school—a place usually free of parental surveillance—there is also a sense of solidarity and shared cultural and linguistic practices. Mrs. Malik explained that she has known many families in her Muslim community since she was a girl in Karachi, Pakistan: "There is a community sense here, everybody pretty much leaves each other alone because everybody has her own life, but there is always something to fall back on. We are very lucky in that sense. Taahir benefits because a lot of my friends' children are in school with him, so if he is going to their house, I know where he's going." Although youth express ambivalent feelings about being watched at school and admit that there are downsides to this type of closeness,

such as gossip and little or no privacy, they by and large welcome community support networks and are invested in being a part of them.

SEARCHING FOR SUCCESS IN SILICON VALLEY

Middle- and upper-middle-class Desis have settled into neighborhoods and socialize within their growing communities. Such communities are largely organized by class lines, where upper-middle-class Desis are professionals and middle-class Desis are assembly line workers. In the high-tech industry, these two poles can be quite disparate and the rift between them large. Anna Lee Saxenian (1985: 83) notes that the semiconductor industry has a distinctive corporate structure, in which "the industry . . . employs an unusually large proportion of professional and managerial employees alongside an equally large, but minimally skilled, production workforce. This top-heavy and bifurcated labor force fundamentally shaped the social structure and urban geography of Silicon Valley." This dichotomy has led to a spate of well-paid professional managerial jobs that require a bachelor's degree or higher, alongside low-paid assembly line and clerical jobs characterized by poor pay and benefits and less than satisfactory working conditions, especially for unskilled assembly line work.

On the whole, the high-tech industry pays higher wages than the national average (Rogers and Larsen 1984) and provides a greater number of assembly-line and wage-labor positions to women than non-high-tech industries, though they offer less than the union wages offered in cannery work in this region (G. Matthews 2003: 141). In these lower echelons, Asian women dominate the blue-collar rungs of the high-tech industry, and numerous mothers of middle-class teens held such positions.[12] During the boom, work was plentiful and these employees were offered job security, competitive wages, and sometimes even stock options and bonuses. During slower periods, however, they are the first to be laid off from assembly line jobs and have great difficulty finding other jobs, as production is increasingly outsourced (Pellow and Park 2002: 65).

Even Desis who are excelling in this industry face difficulty in a White-dominated upper tier. The 1995 Glass Ceiling Commission report indicates that Asians are not advancing despite their high qualifications. Historically, Asian Americans have been paid less than Whites for various types of employment, and this trend continues. Even in the late nineteenth

and early twentieth centuries, Whites were paid higher wages to do less grueling work, leaving the more intensive labor and lower compensation to Asians and Mexicans (Pellow and Park 2002: 35). Bernard Wong (2006) reports a similar finding in his study of Chinese Americans in Silicon Valley, and notes that while most are engineers, some become entrepreneurs because of the glass ceilings to advancement that they face. As recently as 1990, Asians who are better educated than Whites were paid 14 percent less and promoted less frequently for entry-level tech jobs, and this trend continues a decade later (Wong 2006: 31). Indeed, despite stories of those who have beaten the odds, even those who are doing well are not doing as well as their White peers.

A top-heavy housing structure mirrors the top-heavy employment structure of the high-tech industry. While the large and wealthy professional upper-middle-class workforce lives in the northern and western regions as well as in South Fremont, the lower income production workforce is concentrated in the flat "south side" of San Jose (Rogers and Larson 1984). Within San Jose, the northern and western regions of the city are far more desirable than the eastern and southern sides and have been called "bedroom communities of less educated minorities" (Saxenian 1985: 87) although even this region has gentrified significantly over the past decade. Middle-class Desi families who moved into these areas in the late 1970s and early 1980s have benefited from this property appreciation. For newcomers, however, settling in takes tremendous capital. Despite the ongoing growth, zoning laws and prohibitively high housing prices have made this area especially challenging for newer middle-class residents. Bidding wars over residences have displaced lower income residents to cheaper housing in the southern and eastern corners of San Jose as well in outlying cities. In this economy, even previously undesirable areas of San Jose have become attractive. Steve Dinh, an administrator at Waverly High in East San Jose, has lived in Silicon Valley for over twenty years. He described the rise in desirability of East San Jose, where many middle-class Desi families live: "I remember these homes up and down Capitol Expressway. When we bought our home there, it was $120,000. They just built the home in about 1980. While the same homes today are going for about $450,000 or $500,000." Such growth has now been accepted as commonplace and has created a class-divided society in Silicon Valley.

When Desi families who are now middle class first arrived in Silicon

Valley in the late 1970s and early 1980s, even the lower income portions of San Jose were out of their range. After initially renting apartments, two or three families—usually kin—pooled their resources to buy a home to share until they could help one another amass enough capital to buy their own homes. For example, Mrs. Kapoor, the mother of Meru and Jasbir, teenage girls, explained how her family and her husband's four brothers all moved from Yuba City in search of more regular and profitable work than the peach orchards where their family had worked for the past twenty years. The five brothers initially bought and shared two homes in San Jose and eventually purchased three more homes nearby. Middle-class families like the Kapoors have created a neighborhood out of what seems like undifferentiated tract housing by dropping by each other's homes daily and being intricately involved in each other's lives. Every afternoon at 3 o'clock, when she returns from her 6 a.m. shift as a quality inspector at a microfilm company, Mrs. Kapoor makes chai and samosas for the steady flow of family members that begin appearing. Mrs. Kapoor talks about wanting a bigger house, but that would mean moving out of this area in which so many family members are within close walking or driving distance, and it does not seem worth the trade-off.

Lower-income residents of Silicon Valley have felt the effects of an exceedingly high cost of living, especially those working in the lower echelons of the high-tech industry.[13] In 1999, before the bubble burst, dot-com hopefuls and "Y2K" specialists occupied every available rental, and desperation for housing was at an all-time high. Mrs. George commented that she even had to unlist her telephone number because Desis in search of housing kept identifying her Indian name in the phone book and asking to rent out her garage as a living space. Noting this trend, Greene's assistant principal, Mr. Lopez, reports an influx of both wealthier Desi students whose parents are high-tech professionals and middle-class youth whose parents relocated from other regions of the United States or directly from South Asia to seek blue-collar employment during the fertile economic period of the mid- to late 1990s. Commenting on the changing socioeconomic character of the San Jose area, he remarked, "Silicon Valley is getting richer. People on subsidy can't afford to live here any more. Some of our kids' families overcome that by doubling or tripling up on homes or converting garages into rooms."

While upper-middle-class families have steadily moved into larger,

newer homes in gated communities, most middle-class Desis still occupy the same modest homes they bought twenty years ago, when they moved to Silicon Valley. Although residents in these areas could profit substantially from selling their home on the current market, they concede that this same pattern of real estate appreciation would preclude them from affording a larger home. Thus, while home prices have risen dramatically in this and other parts of San Jose, populations in these areas have not changed significantly. Homes bought for fifty thousand dollars that are now worth half a million and more still have iron security bars on their windows and doors and old cars raised up on cinder blocks in the front yard. Most middle-class Desis are reluctant to leave their jobs, schools, and communities in San Jose and opt instead to stay in their current homes. Even families that have earned significantly more by shrewd investments and business ventures choose not to move out of their neighborhoods and instead remain close to friends and family despite their ability to aspire to join a wealthier social circle. As will become clear, this type of loyalty is paramount to meanings of community and defines the values and aspirations of Desi teens.

These shifts have pushed some long-time residents who are not homeowners farther and farther out of the Bay Area. This was especially the case for high school faculty and administrators, some of whom commute one to two hours each way to live in affordable communities. Monique Albert, an African American teacher who grew up in the Bay Area, declared in frustration that she can no longer afford to rent an apartment in South Fremont near Mercer High School, where she teaches: "Housing in the South Bay is too expensive. You don't have much choice if you don't have a lot of money." The area now draws wealthier, upwardly mobile professionals, many of whom are Asian or Asian American; they displace less wealthy Whites, African Americans, and Latinos. Angela Shen, an art teacher at Mercer who attended the high school as a student in the early 1980s, reflected on the drastic changes Fremont has undergone: "Back then there were a lot more [families with] Hispanic surnames. I think a lot of them have been pushed out in the meantime. The Asian population was somewhere around 27 percent, and it tended to be extremely high-end families—generally, not recent immigrants, not recent in terms of coming in the last five years." Overarching narratives of success, however, can often mask all of these deterrents.

The Promise of Technology and the Amrikan Dream • As families looked to the high-tech industry for opportunities, they were particularly interested in upward mobility and prosperity for their children. Especially as Desi teens weighed their options during high school in the 1990s, the promise of technology and narratives of progress in this region underscored differences of class while also suggesting means of class mobility. During the late 1990s, Silicon Valley was awash in stories of success, from fourteen-year-olds who had created portals from their bedrooms to twenty-somethings who had made millions overnight from dot-com ventures. Social events were abuzz with names of promising venture capitalists, IPOs of dot-com stock, and new opportunities in technology infrastructure. Being in any other industry meant missing out on what was arguably the second gold rush.

At the height of the dot-com boom, technology was a strong and pervasive force. Consider this conversation in a tenth-grade English class on a hot San Jose morning. In a packed classroom, fifteen- and sixteen-year-olds squirmed to keep from sticking to the plastic chairs and desks, perhaps from fear of becoming attached permanently. Reviewing vocabulary with his class, Mr. Suarez asked, "Who can tell us the meaning of 'aristocracy'?" Met with a silence broken only by the occasional rustling of a note being passed, he implored, "Can *anyone* name an aristocrat?" A lone hand went up and produced an excited "Yes, Stephanie!" from Mr. Suarez. "Bill Gates," she answered, with a confidence that inspired several students to nod in agreement and take note. For Stephanie and countless other teens, the promise of technology is the prospect of vast economic gain and social status to middle- and upper-middle-class youth alike. It has transformed the very idea of success into something ever more accessible, even for those whose opportunities are otherwise limited.

The high-tech field has especially shaped local notions of progress and contributed to defining values and aspirations for its residents (English-Lueck 2002). During the high-tech boom of the late 1990s, Silicon Valley presented Desis with the opportunity to achieve their Amrikan Dream: to make a fortune in a prestigious technology career, become flush with cash to satisfy material desires and help family, and to retire early. Careers in science, technology, and medicine are widely valorized and coveted in South Asia and among diasporic Desis. Internationally renowned branches of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) are highly competitive and

produce some of the most sought-after engineers worldwide. Indeed, seats in science colleges are prestigious and highly coveted. These values complement those in Silicon Valley well. Hundreds of H1-B workers from India have made IIT a household name in the Bay Area. The technology-saturated environs of Silicon Valley further this cultural preference for technology. Charles Darrah (2001) terms this phenomenon "technoculture," in which technology creates a worldview of assumptions, values, and practices from technology. Technoculture extends beyond machines and gadgets to "the nature of work in high tech industries and the location of Silicon Valley in a global system of production and consumption" (4). Technology pervades many aspects of economic and social life, and it is difficult to overstate its ubiquity in this area.

In the late 1990s, technology's overwhelming promise made it the obvious avenue for success. Abhijeet, a middle-class Sikh Punjabi boy, asserted, "There are *lots* of lucrative opportunities around here. If you're not going into computers, you're nuts!" Some youth do not aspire to enter the high-tech field, but the majority regard it as a strong possibility. To not consider it would be foolish, as I was told on numerous occasions by parents who kindly suggested that my time would be better spent actually working in the high-tech industry rather than asking them countless questions about it. Technology has been a part of their lives since childhood, and Desi teens are comfortable with the technology of video games, pagers, instant messaging, and more recently, cell phones and handheld communication devices. Even middle-class kids who do not have computers at home have grown up using them in school. In these ways, the high-tech industry has insinuated itself into the local imagination.

California itself has played a role in shaping local versions of success. Glenna Matthews (2003: 6) notes that "generations of Americans and those abroad have been schooled to believe that California is *the* place where dreams come true." Since its founding, Silicon Valley has encouraged original ventures rather than joining established ones. Hewlett-Packard began this trend, and stories of the first Apple computer being made in a garage only fuel this type of success. Indeed, the lore of companies born in basements disrupts conventional trajectories to success that rely on higher education, job experience, and gradual upward mobility.

The massive influx of venture capital into local businesses made these dreams loom large in the 1990s. For example, in 1993, the San Jose *Mercury*

News reported that three hundred new firms were funded by venture capital each year in Silicon Valley, including new start-ups and spin-offs from existing firms and "restarts" of previously floundering companies (quoted in Bahrami and Evans 2000: 173–74). Desis play a visible role as venture capitalists in the high-tech industry. Media accounts happily underscore this point in such features as *Fortune*'s cover story on South Asians in Silicon Valley (May 15, 2000). The article dubs this group the "Indian Mafia" and notes that they "invest in one another's companies, sit on one another's boards, and hire each other in key jobs. Many live in close proximity and hang out together" and have created companies that have a collective market value of $235 billion. With such stories from their own Community, it is not surprising that Desi teenagers consider themselves imminent millionaires.

In this innovative environment, even failure is met with aplomb. One of the tenets of Silicon Valley entrepreneurship is the absence of stigma for "honest failures," as well as the belief that this positive attitude toward failure has contributed to the ultimate success of many high-tech companies (Bahrami and Evans 2000: 177). Silicon Valley during the late 1990s was a self-contained space of unlimited possibilities; such an environment "allows people to celebrate risk taking and entrepreneurship, since the costs of failure are not viewed as catastrophic; new opportunities are just around the corner" (Darrah 2001: 4). There were no barriers to entry: "Like the first gold rush, all one needs in Silicon Valley is passion, commitment to hard work, and a little luck and imagination" (Pellow and Park 2002: 2). Skilled employees, venture capital, a fast growth rate, and an expanding market for products make the high-tech industry advance and develop at a much more rapid pace than other industries (Rogers and Larsen 1984: 29) and furthers the possibility of the Amrikan Dream for Desis.

Silicon Dreams • Stories of unimaginable wealth and advancement were commonplace in Silicon Valley in the late 1990s. Mrs. Malik has watched the booming prosperity of her Pakistani Muslim community. With her son Taahir nodding in agreement, she recited a local legend: "It's normal to retire in your early thirties over here." Noting my quizzical look, she elaborated, "I don't know about the East Coast, but over *here* you do these things. Every second car you see over here is a BMW, a Mercedes, a Por-

sche. The latest cars are on the street; it's just the economy! The economy is so amazing. It's good, it's job security." Lucrative opportunities in the high-tech industry have made this type of California lifestyle commonplace for upper-middle and even some middle-class families. Youth of all class backgrounds aspire to owning luxury automobiles and living lives filled with various material comforts. Especially in a place like Silicon Valley, where extraordinary wealth has become typical, pressure to display success to one's community is compelling. Even middle-class families are able to use their home equity and job security to acquire consumer goods not typically associated with middle-class living, such as luxury automobiles and high-end home electronics. The ability to make money as a means to acquiring these status-conferring items, whether temporary or long term, is a valued asset.

The potential of technology is evident to teens of all class backgrounds; the types of training they complete and the positions they are drawn to, however, can vary significantly. Upper-middle-class youth who study computer engineering at four-year colleges receive a high-quality education irrespective of the career they eventually pursue. Many of those who had gravitated toward medicine or business are considering computer science and engineering. Technology is also shaping the aspirations of middle-class youth who see it as an opportunity to succeed quickly and dramatically. Youth in middle-class families by and large aspire to be wealthy, but not necessarily through lengthy undergraduate and graduate programs that lead to long-term job stability or upward class movement. Unlike upper-middle-class Desi youth, success for middle-class youth is rarely articulated solely in terms of educational achievement or long-term career advancement. More often, parents define upward mobility in terms of their children having a better life than they do in terms of commodities, homes, material acquisitions, and job security.

During the high-tech boom of the 1990s, Desis were able to create opportunities for their children by encouraging them to explore new niches in the high-tech industry. New types of technology jobs offered middle-class Desi teens an inroad into the white-collar world. Between highly skilled engineering positions and grueling assembly line work emerged an intermediate category of technology workers: systems operators, Microsoft Windows administrators, and other "low-tech" entrees into the high-tech world.[14] More prestigious than assembly line work yet far less up-

wardly mobile than engineering jobs, such categories of work offer the distinctive title of computer professional as well as monetary benefits in an industry that signifies modernity and progress. Youth considered these "grey-collar" technology jobs to be a faster, easier, and more profitable path to getting ahead than the assembly line technology work of their parents. Accordingly, middle-class Desi teens set their sights on junior college and training institutes and degrees in specialized programs that can become obsolete. Indeed, these positions offer opportunities to achieve the Amrikan Dream in ways previously unimaginable.

Desis laud Silicon Valley not only for its economic opportunities, but also for its multicultural character and color-blind narratives of advancement. Mr. Shah, the father of Tara, an upper-middle-class girl, enthusiastically explained that he has no fear of glass ceilings based on his race. He has had no problem advancing at his company and noted, "Right now being an Indian in Silicon Valley is a huge plus. People would rather give money to an Indian than a White guy . . . maybe because I'm in the computer field where things are more progressive. It's basically what you do that counts, not who you are." Mr. Shah's assertion that being Desi could actually help rather than hinder one's advancement only bolsters the strength of the Amrikan Dream in the Desi mind. Like Mrs. Malik's comment, it underscores that the high-tech industry offers a chance to achieve greatness regardless of educational background, class status, and even ethnic and racial background.

As Mr. Shah reflects, the multicultural nature of Silicon Valley during this period seems to make it a place where Desis feel comfortable with being people of color. Mrs. Malik likewise remarks that while she has experienced discrimination here, it pales in comparison to her experiences elsewhere in the United States: "I think Silicon Valley is a very good place to live because if you go to other states or anything, you realize that there is discrimination." Being in a Desi-saturated area is regarded positively. Mrs. Oberoi, mother of Dilip, an upper-middle-class Hindu boy, explained, "I am glad we raised [our children] in the Silicon Valley. There are lots of Indian families, culture, musicians, and singers in this area, good exposure for them. Even in the school there [are] the multicultural activities." The diverse population of this area makes it easier for the Desi communities to maintain their exclusive social circles without seeming exclusionary.

The ways adults in Silicon Valley valorize not only the high-tech industry but also Silicon Valley creates a compelling case for their children to follow suit. Desi teens, along with other youth, expressed pride and loyalty to the area in remarks such as "It's so cool how we live in Silicon Valley—we control the world!" and "Why would you want to leave the Bay Area? It's the best place in the world!" Even those who do not consider this region particularly exciting nonetheless speak highly of it and note its transformation. Simran, a middle-class Sikh girl, related a conversation with visiting relatives about her perceptions of Silicon Valley: "They thought San Jose was really *bad*, that there are a lot of gangsters. I'm all, 'It's not even like that!' They're all, 'You can't walk outside in the middle of the night.' You can't because, like, there's nowhere to go." Like her peers, Simran is reluctant to even consider leaving this beloved area, despite any shortcomings.

CONCLUSION

Desis in California are in a far more advantageous position than a century ago, when they were barred from citizenship and land ownership. They have made a prominent place for themselves in the changing landscape of Silicon Valley. Establishing enduring ties to this location roots this Desi Community to this place and maps undifferentiated, generic suburban spaces into distinct neighborhoods with extended family and friends, places of religious worship, and ethnic stores and restaurants. Not only do adults participate in this model of community interaction, but children also see the value of it in their social lives.

The high-tech industry has shaped the aspirations and priorities of Desi teens in Silicon Valley. Nonetheless, widening socioeconomic gaps are only partially hidden in a region overjoyed by its own success. The types of futures that middle-class teens dream about can be quite different from those of upper-middle-class youth. For both, however, this industry provides narratives for success as well as specific material desires and informs their sense of style. In the next chapter I elaborate on this style as part of a broader discussion of Desi teen culture and examine how Desi teens orient themselves within their communities and schools and map campus space and activities according to their own cultural logics.